

Who runs it after launch

Building an AI system is a project. **Keeping it valuable is ongoing work**, and the two need different things. When a pilot that worked gets dropped, the usual reason is that nobody owned what happened after launch: it had a sponsor but no owner, and project funding but no operating budget.



THE FIVE PIECES OF AN OPERATING MODEL ————— not one involves machine learning

- 1

Funding FOR RUNNING IT

A project budget asks "can we build this". An operating budget asks "can we keep this running". **If the answer is "we'll figure it out later", the funding isn't in place yet.**
- 2

Ownership ONE NAME

One accountable person whose name you can write down. **If ownership is split, nobody is accountable.**
- 3

Roadmap WHAT CHANGES NEXT

What improves next quarter, what gets retired. Without one, your AI keeps running on launch-day rules while the business changes.
- 4

Run and maintain DAY TO DAY

The people who build a pilot are usually not the people who keep it running. Building it and keeping it reliable are different jobs.
- 5

Decommission RETIRING IT

Not every agent needs to run forever, and retiring one on purpose is normal. The risk is an agent nobody remembers that is still running: technical debt, and sometimes a security risk.

WHICH ONE DID YOU BUILD ————— the ordinary-Tuesday test

AN AI EVENT

It has a start, some excitement and an end, and its success still **depends on the person who built it.**

AN AI CAPABILITY

It keeps running through new leadership, shifting priorities and staff turnover, because it has **become part of how the business works.**

The test: on an ordinary Tuesday eighteen months from now, if the person who built it has left, does it still deliver value? **One organisation kept funding and owning its AI after launch. The other stopped paying attention once the launch was over.**

Monday morning

FIVE WORDS, FIVE NAMES

Take one AI capability you're proud of. On one sheet of paper write five words – **Funding, Ownership, Roadmap, Run, Decommission** – and next to each write a **name**, not a description. Who pays next year? Whose one name owns it? Who decides what it becomes, who gets the call when it breaks, who retires it?

*If you catch yourself writing "the project team" or "we'll decide later", you've found the weakest part of your operating model. **Fix the empty box before hundreds of people depend on it.***

OPERATOR INSIGHT · LAYER 5

Pilots don't scale. Operating models do.

"Your AI maturity will never exceed your operational maturity."

Free

Score your own operation – the AI-Ready Operations Assessment turns all five layers into a readiness check, from "ad hoc" to "AI-ready". [vihrenlabs.gumroad.com/l/rmkje](https://vihrenlabs.com/l/rmkje)